

WELCOMING RAM
Folk performances ahead of the Pran Pratishtha ceremony in the temple town

Supreme Court of India. Ambekar is clear that the RSS will not participate in movements for Mathura and Kashi as it did for the Ram Mandir. "There is a routine legal process that can deal with such issues," he says.

MODI AND THE SOUL OF INDIA

While Modi has fulfilled much of the Sangh Parivar's long-pending agenda, the prime minister has also focused on India's economic growth in addition to implementing a slew of welfare schemes for the poor. Nripendra Misra, who worked closely with Modi while he was his principal secretary in the first term, believes that the prime minister in his second term has focused on building strong linkages between culture and development. He believes that Modi recognised that India's rich cultural heritage was neither acknowledged nor conserved, or even developed and is now ensuring this gap is filled. "The prime minister," he says, "is now focusing strongly on revitalising the soul of the nation. He is providing soul to the concepts of governance, development, social equity and society." Along with a cultural renaissance, the promise of Viksit Bharat fits well with the Modi narrative. Ashwini Vaishnaw, the Union minister of railways, believes that culture and a sense of identity in all its dimensions play an important role in the nation's growth. "Under Modiji," he says, "we are a country that no longer feels helpless but is confident of achieving things, being at the cutting edge of innovation and building a better country—all the structures of a good society are falling into place." Adds Bharat Lal, secretary general, National Human Rights Commission, who has served with Modi for decades, "What the PM has demonstrated is that India has the capacity to correct historical wrongs and make them right. He ensured that justice is done. It is a coming of age, a cultural assertion, where powerful emotions and sentiments are respected and smoothly implemented by taking everyone together. Internationally, too, it shows the PM's ability to resolve contentious issues in a peaceful manner."

The rest of the world is closely watching the progress of both Modi and the RSS's Hindutva agenda. They have already noticed the Hindu revival that has taken place in the past decade with the rise of the BJP, but foreign policy experts do not yet know how the US and the western world will accommodate the new sense of nationalism guiding India's foreign policy. D.B. Venkatesh Varma, a former diplomat, last posted as Indian ambassador to Russia, believes that India's cultural and religious sentiment now will invariably spill into political assertiveness both within and outside India. "India's foreign policy," he says, "will be assessed increasingly through this new discourse. India is not merely just another state but a civilisational one that is now asserting its place in the global order. This will be noted abroad, particularly in the West. They may not like India's assertiveness, but will learn to accept it."

THE POLITICAL IMPLICATIONS

When it comes to domestic politics, most experts have no doubt that the Ram Mandir will give a major boost to Modi's already strong prospects for a third term, but ace political strategist Prashant Kishor has a different take. "These are all hyped-up things," says Kishor. "At best, it will bring some mojo back to the BJP supporters. For all the hype and the hoopla, it will not add votes to the BJP kitty by itself. That's because it is not going to get people to change their mind and vote for the BJP. What it may do is result in a better turnout of BJP cadre to the hustings, which helps them increase their vote percentage." So, what then will determine the outcome of the 2024 election? Of that Kishor is sure. It's Brand Modi, which has subsumed everything under it. "People are voting for Modi," he says. "He is seen not just as a Hindu *hriday samrat* who evokes nationalist pride but also as someone who has brought India laurels on foreign policy and who takes care of the poor by his welfare schemes." According to Kishor, Brand Modi's trump cards are Hindutva, nationalism, beneficiaries and an aggressive cadre. Another psephologist who doesn't want to be named says constructing the Mandir is equivalent to the moon landing by India last year. "While people will applaud initially," he says, "it will soon wear off and they